

GUJARAT ORIGIN

Bhindi Sambhariya

Stuffed Okra with Spiced Coconut Filling
A Gujarati Technique of Patient Craft

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Bhindi Sambhariya

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Art of the Stuffed Vegetable

"Sambhariya" refers to a category of stuffed vegetable dishes within Gujarati cooking, and bhindi sambhariya — okra slit and filled with a spiced mixture of besan, coconut, sesame, and jaggery before being shallow-fried or cooked in a covered pan — represents one of the technique's most beloved applications. The dish demands genuine patience: each okra pod must be carefully slit without cutting all the way through, then individually stuffed, a process that rewards careful, unhurried hands.

The filling itself is a study in Gujarati flavor balance, combining the earthiness of roasted besan and coconut with the sweetness of jaggery and the tang of amchur or lemon, all brought together with warming spices — a microcosm of the same sweet-tangy-spicy sensibility found throughout this collection, concentrated into a single stuffing that transforms simple okra into something considerably more special.

Because of the care required, bhindi sambhariya tends to appear more often at gatherings and special family meals than as a rushed weeknight dish, standing as one of several "sambhariya" preparations in Gujarati cuisine — the same stuffing technique is also applied to small eggplants and other vegetables, each adapting the core filling to its own shape and texture.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Art of the Stuffed Vegetable, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Part of the broader Gujarati "sambhariya" tradition of stuffed vegetable dishes, also applied to eggplant and other vegetables. Requires genuine patience and careful technique, making it more common at gatherings and special meals than rushed weeknight cooking. The filling itself embodies Gujarati cuisine's characteristic sweet-tangy-spicy balance in concentrated form. A dish that showcases the meticulous, hands-on craft valued in traditional Gujarati home cooking.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

30m	20m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small pan, for dry roasting the besan
- Mixing bowl
- Sharp paring knife, for slitting the okra
- Wide kadai or pan, for cooking

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Bhindi sambhariya keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days, though it's best enjoyed fresh, as okra can turn slightly soft and lose its pleasant bite with storage. Reheat gently in a pan rather than a microwave to help maintain some texture.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the okra

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Okra (bhindi), medium-sized	1 lb	450 g	1 lb

For the stuffing

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Besan (gram flour)	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Fresh coconut, grated (or dried, unsweetened)	3 tbsp	20 g	3 chammach
Sesame seeds	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Cumin powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Jaggery, grated	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Amchur (dried mango powder) or lemon juice	1 tsp	3 g or 15 ml	1 chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4.5 g	to taste
Oil, for the stuffing	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For cooking

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Choose okra pods that are medium-sized and firm — very large pods tend to be tough and fibrous, while very small ones are difficult to stuff. Dried unsweetened coconut works well if fresh isn't available, though fresh gives the best flavor. Amchur provides a distinctive tang that's hard to replicate exactly, but lemon juice is a very reasonable substitute.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Stuffing

01 DRY ROAST THE BESAN

Dry roast the besan in a small pan over low heat for 3–4 minutes, stirring constantly, until it turns a shade darker and smells nutty and toasted.

02 MIX THE STUFFING

Combine the roasted besan with the coconut, sesame seeds, coriander powder, cumin powder, turmeric, chili powder, jaggery, amchur, salt, and oil. Mix thoroughly until well combined and slightly moist.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Stuffing, continued

Chef tip. the stuffing should hold together slightly when pressed but still be crumbly enough to pack easily into the slit okra.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The stuffing should taste balanced across sweet, tangy, and spicy notes when sampled on its own — adjust jaggery, amchur, or chili powder to taste before proceeding.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Stuffing & Cooking the Okra

03 SLIT THE OKRA

Wash and thoroughly dry the okra pods — excess moisture is the enemy of good bhindi. Trim the tops, then make a lengthwise slit down each pod, being careful not to cut all the way through.

04 STUFF EACH POD

Carefully pack a spoonful of stuffing into each slit okra pod, pressing gently to fill without tearing.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Stuffing & Cooking the Okra, continued

05 TEMPER AND COOK

Heat oil in a wide kadai and add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then cumin seeds and asafoetida. Carefully arrange the stuffed okra in the pan in a single layer.

06 COOK COVERED, THEN UNCOVERED

Cover and cook on low heat for 10–12 minutes, then uncover and continue cooking for another 5–8 minutes, turning gently, until the okra is tender with lightly browned spots and no longer sticky or slimy.

Texture indicator. properly cooked bhindi should feel tender but not mushy, with no trace of sliminess — the uncovered cooking stage at the end helps evaporate excess moisture.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Washing the okra and cooking it while still wet, or not drying it thoroughly beforehand, is the most common cause of slimy bhindi. Always pat okra completely dry before slitting and cooking.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of a Gujarati thali alongside dal, rice, and roti.
- A special-occasion dish, often prepared for guests and family gatherings given the effort involved.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served on a plate arranged neatly to showcase the stuffed pods, garnished with fresh coriander.

Family Style

- A cherished special dish for weekend or festive family meals.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Technique Right

- Thoroughly drying the okra before cooking is the single most important step for avoiding sliminess — don't rush this.
- Cooking uncovered at the end helps any remaining moisture evaporate, further improving texture.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The stuffing can be made a day ahead and refrigerated, ready to use when you're prepared to slit and stuff the okra.
- This dish is best cooked close to serving time rather than reheated extensively, to preserve the okra's texture.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks lightly shallow-fry the stuffed okra in a separate pan before the final covered cooking step, which helps seal in the stuffing and adds extra flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

155 kcal	4 g	15 g	9 g	5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Mustard, Sesame. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Ringan Sambhariya	the same technique and stuffing applied to small eggplants instead of okra.
Sambhariya Vegetable Mix	some households combine both stuffed okra and eggplant in a single dish.
Dry Bhindi Sambhariya	a drier version with less oil, cooked down further for a more concentrated flavor.

Why is my bhindi slimy?

Almost always insufficient drying before cooking, or overcrowding the pan, which traps moisture. Dry thoroughly and cook in a wide, uncrowded pan.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make the stuffing less sweet?

Yes — reduce the jaggery to taste; the dish will still have good flavor from the coconut, sesame, and spices.

Can I bake instead of pan-fry the stuffed okra?

A hot oven (400°F / 200°C) for about 20 minutes works as an alternative, though the traditional stovetop method gives the most authentic texture and flavor.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Bhindi	Hindi/Gujarati for okra, the primary vegetable in this dish.
Sambhariya	a Gujarati technique and dish category referring to stuffed vegetables.
Amchur	dried mango powder, used for tang in the stuffing.
Til	Gujarati for sesame seeds, part of this dish's distinctive stuffing.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Bhindi Sambhariya

30m	20m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

OKRA

Okra	450 g

STUFFING

Besan	35 g
Fresh coconut	20 g
Sesame seeds	10 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Cumin powder	1.5 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Red chili powder	3 g
Jaggery	15 g
Amchur	3 g or 15 ml
Salt	4.5 g
Oil	15 ml

FOR COOKING

Oil	45 ml
Mustard seeds	4 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Asafoetida	pinch

METHOD

01 **Dry roast the besan.** Dry roast the besan in a small pan over low heat for 3–4 minutes, stirring constantly, until it turns a shade darker and smells nutty and toasted.

02 **Mix the stuffing.** Combine the roasted besan with the coconut, sesame seeds, coriander powder, cumin powder, turmeric, chili powder, jaggery, amchur, salt, and oil.

03 **Slit the okra.** Wash and thoroughly dry the okra pods — excess moisture is the enemy of good bhindi.

04 **Stuff each pod.** Carefully pack a spoonful of stuffing into each slit okra pod, pressing gently to fill without tearing.

05 **Temper and cook.** Heat oil in a wide kadai and add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then cumin seeds and asafoetida.

06 **Cook covered, then uncovered.** Cover and cook on low heat for 10–12 minutes, then uncover and continue cooking for another 5–8 minutes, turning gently, until the okra is tender with lightly browned spots and no longer sticky or slimy.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Okra	450 g	
☐	Fresh coconut	20 g	
☐	Coriander powder	3 g	
☐	Turmeric powder	1.5 g	
☐	Jaggery	15 g	
☐	Salt	4.5 g	
☐	Mustard seeds	4 g	
☐	Asafoetida	pinch	
☐	Besan	35 g	
☐	Sesame seeds	10 g	
☐	Cumin powder	1.5 g	
☐	Red chili powder	3 g	
☐	Amchur	3 g or 15 ml	
☐	Oil	see recipe	
☐	Cumin seeds	4 g	

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